



Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospitals Group

Policy and Procedure

Courtyard access and observation – Mental Health

Reference #: FSFH-MENH-POL-0005

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
Fiona Stanley Hospital Fremantle Hospital	Mental Health Service	Medical, Nursing and Allied Health

1. Introduction

The Mental Health Act 2014 requires Mental Health Services (MHS) to provide people experiencing mental illness with high quality care and support based on contemporary best practice to promote recovery in the least restrictive manner, and an environment that is consistent with the patients' needs.¹

The FSFH MHS provides courtyard areas for each inpatient unit as part of the therapeutic environment. The courtyards provide patients with access to outdoor activities and leisure, and an alternative to the lounge room. This policy and procedure outlines the requirements for access and observation of patient's while utilising the inpatient courtyards.

2. Terminology

CARE checks	Hourly visual observation of patients. CARE checks are documented on the Patient Observation Chart.
Environmental checks	Check of the courtyard environment by the Shift Coordinator or their delegate to ensure: - the perimeter wall is undamaged - potential ligature risks are addressed - gates and doors are locked - windows are closed - any unnecessary items are removed

Risk assessment

The gathering and analysis of clinical information related to risks to the consumer and/or others. It includes background (static) risk factors interacting with acute (dynamic) risk factors and the consumers current diagnosis and Mental State Examination to provide a risk assessment framework for clinical judgment and decision making. An accurate assessment of risk cannot be established until safety planning is completed.

3. Policy

- All patients will have a risk assessment completed on admission and as required. The risk assessment will inform the individual patient's observation requirements and will be documented on the Patient Observation Chart. Refer to the Patient Observation – Specialling and close observations policy.
- A patient currently being specialised may access the courtyard with their special, however an additional staff member will be required to supervise other patients in those courtyards where staff supervision is required.

Where closed circuit television is available to assist in courtyard observation, this must not replace clinical observation requirements.

- The safety and security of patients and staff must be maintained during all activities in the courtyard.
- Access to courtyards may be restricted by clinical staff dependant on the clinical acuity of the ward and clinical observation requirements.
- High patient acuity and risk factors including absconding and self-harm, may necessitate direct visual observation of patients using the courtyard.
- Smoking/vaping is not permitted in any of the courtyard areas
- Patients are not permitted to move internal furniture into an outdoor courtyard.

4. Procedure

4.1. Risk mitigation

- Environmental checks of the courtyards by the Shift Coordinator (or delegate) will be conducted at the commencement of each shift and documented on the environmental checklist
- The Mental Health Service duress system provides coverage to all courtyard areas.

At FSH Cockburn Health there are no duress alarm sensors in the courtyard, when a duress is activated in the courtyard the nearest sensor is activated i.e dining room, reception or ground floor group room.

- All staff responsible for supervising the courtyard areas must be familiar with emergency procedures and duress systems including alarms, tags and buttons to call for assistance if required.
- Access to the courtyard will be terminated immediately if there are concerns in relation to the safety and security of patients and/or staff.

4.2. Access and observation

- Courtyard opening times and supervision requirements are detailed in [Appendix 1 & 2](#).
- FSH courtyard location and layout are detailed in [Appendix 3](#)
- FH courtyard location and layout are detailed in [Appendix 4](#)
- FSH-Cockburn Health courtyard location and layout is detailed in [Appendix 5](#).

5. Compliance/performance monitoring

- The Nurse Unit Manager or Clinical Nurse Specialist of the inpatient area is responsible for monitoring compliance with this policy through clinical incident and Combined Hazard or Incident Reporting (CHoIR) reporting and escalating any identified risks.

6. Related policy documents

- FSFHG:
 - Patient Observation – Specialling and Close Observations (FSFH-MENH-POL-0023)
 - Clinical risk assessment and management (FSFH-HW-POL-0017)
 - Anticipating and reducing the risk of unpredictable behaviours (FSFH - MENH-POL-0027)
 - FSH Code Black Mental Health (FSH-MENH-POL-0014)
 - FH Duress alarms and response (FSFH-MENH-PRO-0005)
 - FSH-CH Duress response and management (FSFH-MENH-PPOL-0001)

7. Related standards

- NSQHS

- Clinical Governance
- Partnering with Consumers
- Comprehensive Care
- Recognising and responding to acute deterioration
- Chief Psychiatrists Standards for Clinical Care
 - Care planning.
 - Risk assessment and management
 - Sexual safety of consumers

8. References

1. Parliament of Western Australia. Mental Health Act 2014. Western Australia (Australia): Legislative Assembly; 2014 [cited 2018 Oct 16]. Available from: https://www.legislation.wa.gov.au/legislation/statutes.nsf/main_mrtitle_13534_homepage.html

9. Authorisation

EXECUTIVE SPONSOR: Service Director, Service 5					
Version	Date Issued	Compiled/Revised By	Committee/Consumer Group Consulted	Authorised By	Revision due
1	05/2019	NUMs	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	05/2022
2	01/2021	MHU NUM	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	01/2023
3	05/2021	S5 NUMs	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	01/2023
4	02/2023	S5 NUMs	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	Service 5 Safety Quality Risk Committee	02/2025
5	7/2024	S5 SQR LEAD	Minor Update No change to review date	Lynn Warren (Exec Sponsor)	02/2025
6	03/2025	MH NUMs	MH Clinical Governance Sub Committee	Service 5 Safety Quality and Risk Committee	03/2028

10. Appendices

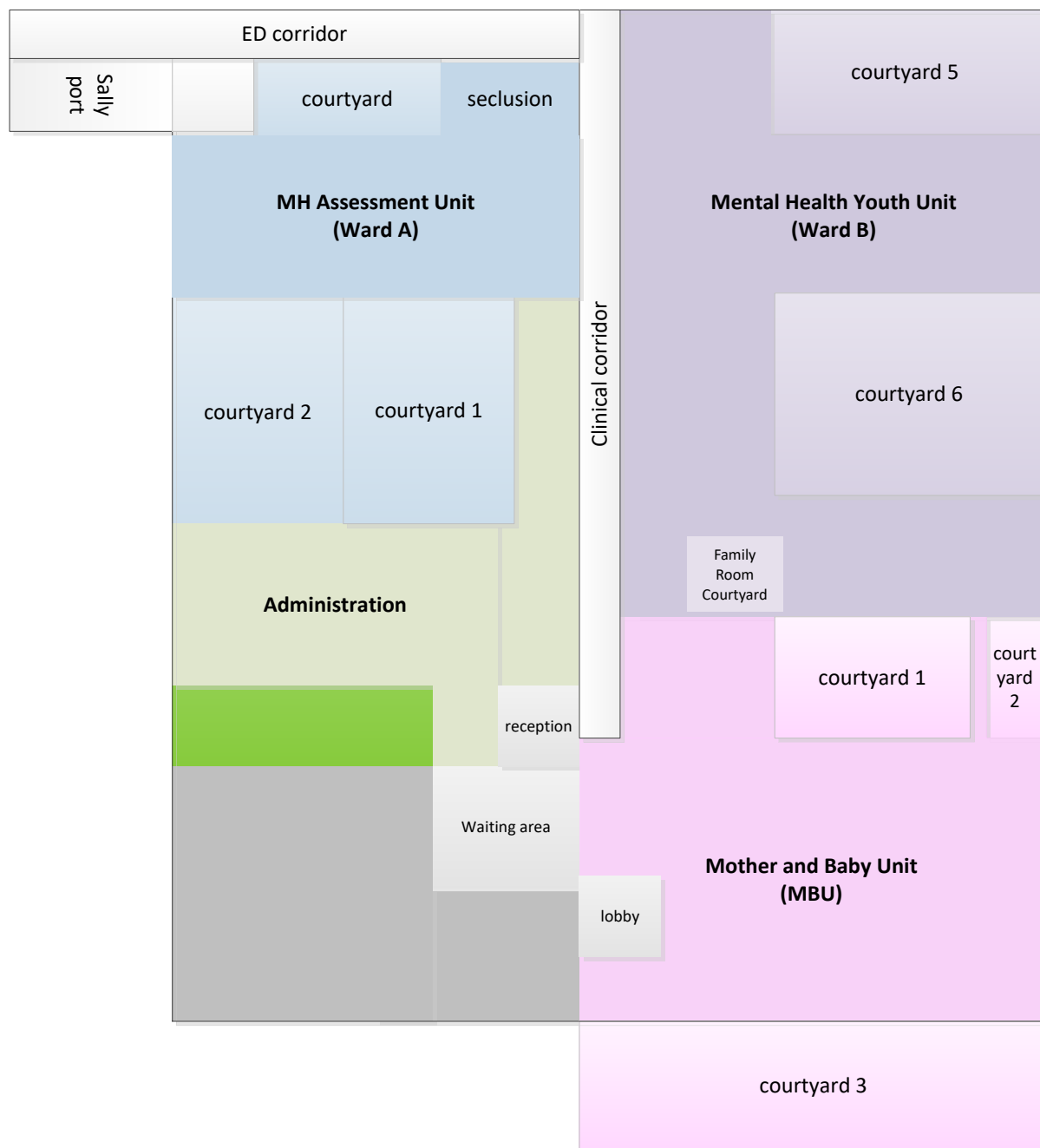
10.1. Appendix 1: FSH Courtyard access and supervision

Location	Opening hours	Supervision
MHA Courtyard 1	08:00 – 22:00 22:00 – 08:00 only with shift Coordinator approval. A staff member must be present with any patients in the courtyard after 22:00 hrs.	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted.
MHA Courtyard 2	Open only when staff supervision is available. Sporting activities to cease by 20:00hrs	A minimum of one staff member must be present at all times when patients are in the Courtyard.
MHB Courtyard 5	Open only when staff supervision is available. Sporting activities to cease by 20:00hrs	A minimum of one staff member must be present at all times when patients are in Courtyard.
MHB Courtyard 6	07:00 – 20:00 Sporting activities to cease by 20:00hrs	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted
MHB Family Room courtyard	Daytime hours	Supervised at all times
MBU Courtyards 1 & 3	08:00 – 20:00	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted
FSH- Cockburn Health Courtyard	08:00-20:00	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted. The courtyard is not locked. Nursing staff will discourage patient access outside of opening hours.

Appendix 2: FH Courtyard access and supervision

Location	Opening hours	Supervision
PICU (W4.1) Courtyard 1	06:00 – 22:00. No access at meal times. 22:00 - 06:00 only with shift Coordinator approval	A minimum of one staff member must be present at all times when patients are in PICU Courtyard 1.
PICU Courtyard 2	06:00 – 22:00 22:00 - 06:00 only with shift Coordinator approval	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted
W4.2 Main Courtyard	06:00 – 22:00	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted
W4.2 Rear Courtyard	Open only when staff supervision is available. Used for Occupational Therapy run groups.	A minimum of one staff member must be present at all times when patients are in Courtyard.
W4.3 Courtyards	06:00 – 22:00	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted
W5.1 Courtyard	05:00 – 21:00 21:00 – 05:00 only with shift Coordinator approval	Environmental and hourly CARE/SAFE checks will be conducted

Appendix 3: FSH Mental Health Unit inpatient courtyard map



Appendix 5: FSH Cockburn Health Courtyard map

